

O-LEVEL NOTES EDITING

O-Level English 1184

Edited by The Hyco Team

Chapter 1. The STAMP CARD Framework

The STAMP CARD Framework

Each letter in STAMP CARD represents one category of grammar error tested in the O-Level editing question. Think of it like a bubble tea stamp card: go through the letters one by one for every numbered line, check each category, and stamp off errors as you find them until you collect all 8 corrections.

Section A — The Nine Categories

The STAMP CARD framework provides nine categories to check on every numbered line. The exam includes eight errors in total across the passage, with two lines deliberately error-free. The framework letters are the categories you check; they do not map one-to-one onto the eight errors.

Error Type	Quick Check Question
S Subject-Verb Agreement	Does the verb agree with the subject in number?
T Tense	Is the verb in the correct tense? Check time markers.
A Articles	Is ‘a’, ‘an’, or ‘the’ used correctly? Based on sound, not spelling.
M Match Pronouns	Does the pronoun match its antecedent in number, gender, and form?
P Prepositions	Is the correct preposition used? Check fixed phrases and collocations.
C Connectors	Is the linking word logically correct? ‘Although’ and ‘but’ cannot be used together.
A Adjective / Adverb (Word Form)	Is it describing a noun (adjective) or a verb / adjective / adverb (adverb, usually -ly)?
R Right Number	Is the noun singular or plural? Does the quantifier match?
D Degree of Comparison	Is the comparative or superlative used correctly? Never double up.

“Stamp out all 8 errors — collect full marks!”

Question Type 1: Apply the STAMP CARD procedure to a passage

Technique: Use STAMP CARD as a checklist for every numbered line. Read the passage once for meaning first, then check each letter in order, prioritising T, S, A.

Step 1: Before reading a single word, write S-T-A-M-P-C-A-R-D in the margin.

Step 2: Read the entire passage once for meaning. Identify the tense and topic. Do not correct yet.

Step 3: For every numbered line, work through each STAMP CARD letter in order. Stop the moment you find the error — each line has at most one.

Step 4: Write your correction clearly. Tick error-free lines. Never leave any line blank.

Key Principle — Why T, S, A First

T, S, and A errors appear in almost every exam passage because they involve the most common grammar rules in English: tense consistency, agreement, and word class. Starting with these three means you will catch the majority of errors efficiently before spending time on the less frequent categories. Think of T-S-A as your first-pass filter.

Chapter 2. Error Types in Detail

Error Types in Detail

Each error type is explained with the full grammar rule, all known sub-patterns, worked examples, and annotated thought-process boxes that explain how an expert reader identifies and corrects each error.

Section A — Tense Errors [STAMP CARD: T]

The tense of every verb must match the time frame the passage is set in. Narrative and recount passages use the past tense. Informative and factual passages use the present tense. Your first read of the passage exists to establish the tense.

Time markers signal the passage tense. Look for them in the opening lines.

Time Marker	Signals	Expected Tense
yesterday, last year, in 2010, once, at that time, in the past	Past events — completed	Past Simple throughout
every day, now, currently, generally, always, nowadays	Present facts or habits	Present Simple throughout
by 2030, in the future, next year, soon, eventually	Predictions or future states	will + base verb

The twelve English tenses. Know the form of all twelve. Past Simple, Present Simple, and Present Perfect are the most frequently tested in editing.

Tense	Form	When to Use	Example
<i>Present Tenses</i>			
Present Simple	verb / verb+s	Habits, routines, general truths, factual passages	She walks.
Present Continuous	am/is/are + -ing	Action happening right now	She is walking.
Present Perfect	have/has + p.p.	Past action with current relevance	She has walked.
Present Perfect Cont.	have/has + been + -ing	Ongoing action from past until now	She has been walking.
<i>Past Tenses</i>			
Past Simple	verb+ed / irreg.	Completed action; narrative passages	She walked.
Past Continuous	was/were + -ing	Ongoing past action; background	She was walking.
Past Perfect	had + p.p.	Earlier of two past events	She had walked.
Past Perfect Cont.	had + been + -ing	Ongoing action before another past event	She had been walking.
<i>Future Tenses</i>			
Future Simple	will + base	Prediction, promise, decision	She will walk.
Future Continuous	will + be + -ing	Action in progress at a future moment	She will be walking.
Future Perfect	will + have + p.p.	Completed before a future point	She will have walked.
Future Perfect Cont.	will + have + been + -ing	Ongoing up to a future point	She will have been walking.

Question Type 1: Identify the wrong tense in a passage

Technique: Establish the passage tense in your first read, then flag any verb that does not match.

Step 1: Read the full passage once. Identify the tense from time markers or context.

Step 2: For each numbered line, identify the main verb.

Step 3: Ask — does this verb match the passage tense?

Step 4: If not, correct it to the appropriate tense form.

Worked Example 1

Correct: She **walk** into the lab yesterday.

Step 1: Time marker: *yesterday* — signals past tense.

Step 2: Main verb: *walk* — base form, not past tense.

Step 3: Correct to Past Simple: *walked*.

Answer: She **walked** into the lab yesterday.

Worked Example 2

Correct: I have seen that film last night.

Step 1: Time marker: *last night* — a specific past time. Locks the event in the past.

Step 2: Present Perfect (*have seen*) cannot co-exist with a specific past time marker.

Step 3: Replace Present Perfect with Past Simple.

Answer: I saw that film last night.

Worked Example 3

Correct: The problem is compounding. (passage describes a state)

Step 1: Structure: *is* + verb form. Ask — is the subject doing an action, or in a condition?

Step 2: The problem is described as being in a worsened state — not actively doing anything.

Step 3: Present participle (*compounding*) = ongoing action. Past participle (*compounded*) = state. Use past participle.

Answer: The problem is **compounded**.

Key Principle — Present vs Past Participle After ‘To Be’

When you see *is/was/are/were* followed by a verb form, ask: is the subject doing something, or in a condition?

- **Doing something** → Present participle (-ing): “The window is breaking.” (right now, actively)
- **In a condition** → Past participle (-ed/irregular): “The window is broken.” (a state)

In the passage, *the problem is compounding* implies the problem is actively compounding something. That is not the intended meaning. The problem has been made worse — it exists in a worsened state. Therefore: **compounded**.

Key Principle — Present Perfect vs Past Simple

The Present Perfect (*have/has* + *p.p.*) links a past event to the present. The Past Simple treats the event as fully over.

- **Use Present Perfect with:** already, yet, ever, never, just, since, for, recently
- **Use Past Simple with:** yesterday, last week, in 2010, at 3pm, on Monday — any specific past time

If a specific past time marker and *have/has* appear together in one clause — that is a T error. A specific time marker locks the event in the past; the Present Perfect cannot be used.

Practice Questions — Tense Errors

Identify and correct the tense error in each sentence.

1. She walk to school every day.
2. He has visit the museum last week.
3. By the time she arrived, he left.
4. The bridge is building across the river. (Describe a completed state.)
5. They are enjoy the show right now.

6. Scientists studied the effects of pollution. (Passage is in present tense.)
7. She already finished her homework. (Use a signal word for Present Perfect.)
8. When the teacher entered, the students finished their test.
9. He has called her yesterday.
10. The results were announcing last Friday.

Section B — Subject-Verb Agreement [STAMP CARD: S]

A singular subject takes a singular verb. A plural subject takes a plural verb. The exam places extra words between the subject and the verb to make the wrong noun look like the subject. Your job is to strip those words out.

Question Type 1: Identify the true subject and match the verb

Technique: Isolate the subject by removing all intervening phrases. Then match the verb to what remains.

Step 1: Identify the main verb in the clause.

Step 2: Ask: who or what is doing or being this? That is the subject.

Step 3: Ignore everything between the subject and the verb (prepositional phrases, relative clauses, parenthetical phrases).

Step 4: Is the true subject singular or plural? Match the verb accordingly.

Worked Example 1

Correct: The average age of caregivers are about 62.

Step 1: Main verb: *are*.

Step 2: Cover *of caregivers*. Remaining subject: *the average age* — singular.

Step 3: Singular subject → singular verb.

Answer: The average age of caregivers **is** about 62.

Worked Example 2

Correct: Each of the boys have a book.

Step 1: Main verb: *have*.

Step 2: Subject: *Each* — an indefinite pronoun, always singular.

Step 3: Singular subject → singular verb.

Answer: Each of the boys **has** a book.

Worked Example 3

Correct: Neither the teacher nor the students was present.

Step 1: Compound subject with *nor* — apply the proximity rule.

Step 2: Subject closest to the verb: *students* — plural.

Step 3: Plural subject → plural verb.

Answer: Neither the teacher nor the students **were** present.

Key Principle — The Proximity Trap

The exam consistently places a plural noun immediately before the verb when the actual subject is singular. Your brain registers the noun closest to the verb — this is the trap.

The fix: Physically cover the words between *of* and the verb with your pen. Read the skeleton that remains. The subject becomes obvious.

“The average age [of caregivers] about 62.” → Subject is *the average age* (singular) → **is**.

Five Tricky S Patterns

Pattern	Rule	Example
Collective nouns	group, team, committee, family — singular in formal writing	The committee has decided.
Indefinite pronouns	each, every, either, neither, no one, someone, everyone — always singular	Everyone has submitted.
‘A number of’ vs ‘The number of’	A number of = plural; The number of = singular	A number of students were late.
Or / nor — proximity rule	Verb agrees with subject closest to it	Neither he nor they were informed.
Relative clauses	Verb in clause agrees with noun the clause refers to	It is the students who are responsible.

Practice Questions — Subject-Verb Agreement

Identify and correct the subject-verb agreement error in each sentence.

1. The group of researchers have published their findings.
2. Each of the students have completed the task.
3. Neither the manager nor the staff members was informed.
4. A number of residents has complained about the noise.
5. The committee have decided to postpone the meeting.
6. The list of requirements have been updated.
7. Everyone in the two classes are expected to attend.
8. Neither John nor his friends was invited to the event.
9. The team of engineers are working on the problem.
10. The number of complaints are rising every month.

Section C — Article Errors [STAMP CARD: A — Articles]

The articles are *a*, *an*, and *the*. Each has a specific function. The key distinction for *a* vs *an* is the sound the following word begins with — not the letter.

Article	When to Use	Examples
<i>a</i>	Before singular countable nouns beginning with a consonant sound. First mention, non-specific.	a book, a university (/j/ sound), a one-way street (/w/ sound), a European (/j/ sound)
<i>an</i>	Before singular countable nouns beginning with a vowel sound. First mention, non-specific.	an apple, an hour (silent h), an honest man (silent h), an MBA (/em/ sound)
<i>the</i>	Before nouns that are specific, already mentioned, or uniquely identifiable. Before superlatives. Before unique nouns.	the book I mentioned, the tallest building, the sun, the Prime Minister
no article	Before plural countable nouns used generally. Before uncountable nouns generally. Before proper nouns.	Dogs are loyal. Water is essential. Singapore is small. She speaks French.

Question Type 1: Choose the correct article

Technique: Say the following word aloud in your head. The first sound — not the first letter — determines whether *a* or *an* is correct.

Step 1: Identify the noun the article precedes.

Step 2: Say the noun aloud. Listen for the first sound: vowel or consonant?

Step 3: Vowel sound → *an*. Consonant sound → *a*.

Step 4: If the noun is specific, already mentioned, or unique, use *the*. If it is a general plural or uncountable noun, use no article.

Key Principle — Sound, Not Spelling

Students default to checking the first letter. This is wrong. Check the first **sound**.

- *University* starts with U, but the first sound is like the letter ‘y’ (consonant). → **a** university.
- *Hour* starts with H, but H is silent. First sound is the vowel in ‘owl’. → **an** hour.
- *MBA* — spoken as a letter name, M sounds like ‘em’ (vowel sound). → **an** MBA.
- *European* starts with E, but first sound is like the letter ‘y’ (consonant). → **a** European.

Rule: Say the word aloud in your head. Whatever sound comes first determines the article.

Worked Example 1

Correct: She is a honest person.

Step 1: Check the first sound of *honest*. The H is silent; first sound is a vowel (like the ‘o’ in ‘hot’).

Step 2: Vowel sound → use *an*.

Answer: She is **an** honest person.

Worked Example 2

Correct: He is an honest and a hardworking employee.

Step 1: Both adjectives (*honest* and *hardworking*) modify the same noun (*employee*).

Step 2: Only one article is needed before a pair of adjectives modifying the same noun.

Step 3: Remove the second article.

Answer: He is an honest and hardworking employee.

Worked Example 3

Correct: She is interested in a environment.

Step 1: The environment = the natural world — a specific, uniquely identifiable concept.

Step 2: Specific / unique → use *the*, not *a*.

Answer: She is interested in **the** environment.

Practice Questions — Article Errors

Identify and correct the article error in each sentence.

1. She waited for a hour before the doctor arrived.
2. He is an university student studying economics.
3. I saw a elephant at the zoo.
4. She is a honest and hardworking person.
5. He bought the some books from the library.
6. She is interested in a environment and sustainability.
7. It was an historic moment for the country.
8. She has a MBA from a prestigious university.
9. He gave an useful piece of advice.
10. The government introduced a new policy to protect a wildlife.

Section D — Pronoun Errors [STAMP CARD: M]

A pronoun must agree with the noun it replaces (its antecedent) in number, gender, and person. It must also be in the correct grammatical form for its role: subject, object, possessive, or reflexive.

Full Pronoun Reference Table

Person	Subject	Object	Possessive	Reflexive
1st singular	I	me	my / mine	myself
2nd singular/plural	you	you	your / yours	yourself / yourselves
3rd singular (m)	he	him	his	himself
3rd singular (f)	she	her	her / hers	herself
3rd singular (n)	it	it	its	itself
1st plural	we	us	our / ours	ourselves
3rd plural	they	them	their / theirs	themselves

Question Type 1: Match pronoun to antecedent in number, gender, and form

Technique: Find the noun the pronoun refers to. Check that the pronoun matches it in number (singular/plural) and gender. Then check the pronoun is in the correct form for its grammatical role.

Step 1: Locate the pronoun and its antecedent (the noun it refers to).

Step 2: Check agreement in number and gender.

Step 3: Identify the grammatical role: subject, object, possessive, or reflexive.

Step 4: If after a preposition, use the object form. If subject and object are the same person, use the reflexive form. Otherwise use the simple object form.

Worked Example 1 — Number

Correct: This patients are grateful for the subsidies.

Step 1: Identify the noun: *patients* — plural.

Step 2: Demonstrative determiner: *this* is for singular nouns; *these* is for plural.

Answer: These patients are grateful for the subsidies.

Worked Example 2 — Subject / Object Form

Correct: Me and my friend went to the library.

Step 1: Pronoun is the subject of the sentence (performing the action). → subject form required.

Step 2: Remove *my friend*: “Me went to the library” → obviously wrong.

Step 3: Subject form = *I*. Convention: put yourself last.

Answer: My friend and I went to the library.

Worked Example 3 — Reflexive Misuse

Correct: Please contact **myself** if you have questions.

Step 1: Check: is the subject and object the same person? *You* are contacting *myself* — different people.

Step 2: Reflexive pronoun is not valid here. Use the simple object form.

Answer: Please contact **me** if you have questions.

Key Principle — Subject vs Object Form

The removal test: Remove the other person from the sentence and read it alone.

“The teacher gave the award to John and I.” → Remove *John*: “gave the award to I” → obviously wrong → use **me**.

The preposition rule: After any preposition (*to, for, with, between, from, at, by, of*) — always use the object form: *me, him, her, us, them*. Never *I, he, she, we, they* after a preposition.

Reflexive pronouns (*myself, himself, etc.*) are only valid when the subject and the object refer to the same person. “He hurt himself” = he hurt his own body. Valid. “Contact myself” = you are contacting yourself. Nonsensical. Invalid.

Key Principle — Singular ‘They’ for Indefinite Antecedents

Indefinite pronouns (*everyone, someone, anyone, each, every*) are grammatically singular but refer to people of unknown or mixed gender. Modern formal English accepts singular *they/their* in these cases.

- “**Everyone** must bring **their** own pen.” → Accepted in formal writing.
- “**Each student** must complete **their** own project.” → Accepted in formal writing.

Caution: The verb still follows the singular antecedent (*everyone has*, not *everyone have*). Singular *they* only affects the pronoun, not the verb. The older form *his or her* is also correct but now considered cumbersome.

In the exam: If the practice question or passage uses singular *they/their* with an indefinite antecedent, do not mark it as an error. The error would be a mismatched *her/his* when the antecedent is genuinely plural or mixed.

Practice Questions — Pronoun Errors

Identify and correct the pronoun error in each sentence.

1. This students are grateful for the help.
2. Him and her completed the task together.
3. The teacher gave the books to John and I.
4. Please send the report to myself by Friday.
5. Everyone must submit their own work by the deadline. (Accept singular ‘their’.)
6. Each student must complete their own project. (Accept singular ‘their’.)
7. The students submitted her work on time.
8. The boy lost his way; she was frightened.
9. Between you and I, the project is behind schedule.
10. Neither of the candidates have submitted their application.

Section E — Preposition Errors [STAMP CARD: P]

A preposition error occurs when the wrong preposition is used with a verb, adjective, or noun. These are fixed phrases (collocations). There is no universal grammar rule. They must be memorised.

Key Principle — Why Prepositions Cannot Be Guessed

Consider *afflicted with*. Why *with* and not *by* or *from*? There is no logical grammar reason. The word *afflicted* simply collocates with *with* in English. Students who reason from logic will get these wrong.

Strategy: Every time you encounter a preposition error in practice, add it to a personal fixed-phrase list. Over time this becomes your most powerful revision tool for this category.

High-Frequency Fixed Preposition Phrases

interested in	responsible for	different from
depend on	consist of	result in
comply with	suffer from	capable of
apologise for	accuse of	associated with
afflicted with	aim at / for	interfere with
grateful for	proud of	dedicated to
participate in	believe in	insist on
good at	afraid of	familiar with
accustomed to	fond of	disappointed with

Question Type 1: Identify the wrong preposition in a fixed phrase

Technique: If a line sounds wrong and the error is not under T, S, A, or M, look at any preposition. Compare it against the fixed-phrase list.

Step 1: Locate the verb, adjective, or noun the preposition is attached to.

Step 2: Ask: what preposition does this word normally take?

Step 3: If the preposition does not match the fixed phrase, replace it.

Step 4: If unsure, mark the line and return to it after finishing the rest of the passage.

Worked Example 1

Correct: She is good in Mathematics.

Fixed phrase: **good at** (a subject or skill). Cannot substitute *in*.

Answer: She is good **at** Mathematics.

Worked Example 2

Correct: He insisted at going alone.

Fixed phrase: **insist on + gerund** (-ing form).

Answer: He insisted **on** going alone.

Worked Example 3

Correct: She is afflicted through chronic illness.

Fixed phrase: **afflicted with**. Non-negotiable — must be memorised.

Answer: She is afflicted **with** chronic illness.

Practice Questions — Preposition Errors

Fill in the blank with the correct preposition, or identify and correct the preposition error.

1. She is very capable handling pressure under stress.
2. The students were grateful the teacher's generous help.
3. The policy aims reducing traffic congestion in the city.
4. He is very interested to learn more about marine biology.
5. She insisted at meeting the director in person.
6. They are very proud in their school's achievements.
7. The committee is responsible of ensuring fair practices.
8. She is very familiar in the procedures required.
9. He was disappointed about his examination results.
10. The new policy is associated to significant economic benefits.

Section F — Connector Errors [STAMP CARD: C]

A connector error occurs when the wrong linking word is used, or when two conflicting connectors appear together in one sentence. The connector must accurately reflect the logical relationship between the clauses it joins.

Logical Connector Types

Relationship	Connectors	Example
Contrast	but, however, yet, although, even though, despite, nevertheless	She studied hard, but she failed.
Cause	because, since, as, due to, owing to	She passed because she studied.
Result	so, therefore, thus, hence, consequently	She studied hard; therefore, she passed.
Addition	and, furthermore, moreover, in addition	She studied hard and revised her notes.
Condition	if, unless, provided that, as long as	She will pass if she studies.
Concession	although, even though, while, whereas	Although unpopular, it was necessary.

Question Type 1: Identify a connector error

Technique: Check that the connector matches the logical relationship. Scan for paired connectors that cannot co-exist. Scan for comma splices with conjunctive adverbs.

Step 1: Identify the connector and the logical relationship it expresses.

Step 2: If *although* appears, scan for *but*. If *because* appears, scan for *so*. One must go.

Step 3: If *however*, *therefore*, *moreover* joins two clauses with only a comma, that is a comma splice. Use a semicolon or full stop instead.

Step 4: If a correlative pair appears (*not only*, *either*, *neither*, *both*, *whether*), verify the second half is correct.

Step 5: If *despite* appears, confirm it is followed by a noun or gerund — not a full clause with subject and verb.

Key Principle — ‘Although’ + ‘But’ Cannot Co-exist

“Although he was tired, but he continued working.” — This is the most commonly tested C error. *Although* is a subordinating conjunction signalling concession. *But* is a coordinating conjunction also signalling contrast. Both signal the same logical relationship. English grammar only allows one connector per logical relationship.

Fix: Keep one, drop the other.

- “**Although** he was tired, he continued working.” Correct.
- “He was tired, **but** he continued working.” Correct.
- “**Although** he was tired, **but** he continued working.” Wrong.

Key Principle — ‘Because’ + ‘So’ Cannot Co-exist

The same logic applies to cause-result pairs. *Because* signals cause; *so* signals result. They cannot appear together in one cause-result sentence.

- “**Because** she was late, **so** she missed the train.” Wrong.
- “**Because** she was late, she missed the train.” Correct.
- “She was late, **so** she missed the train.” Correct.

Rule: One logical relationship → one connector. This is true for all pairs: *although/but*, *because/so*, *even though/yet*, *despite/but*.

Key Principle — Comma Splice with ‘However’

However is a conjunctive adverb, not a coordinating conjunction. It cannot join two independent clauses with only a comma.

- “She studied hard, however she failed.” Wrong (comma splice).

Three fixes:

- Replace the comma with a semicolon: “She studied hard; however, she failed.” Correct.
- Replace the comma with a full stop: “She studied hard. **However**, she failed.” Correct.
- Replace *however* with *but*: “She studied hard, **but** she failed.” Correct.

Common testable error: The same rule applies to *therefore*, *moreover*, *furthermore*, *consequently*, *nevertheless*. All are conjunctive adverbs and cannot be used to join two clauses with only a comma.

Correlative Conjunction Pairs — Memorise These

Correct Pair	Common Error
not only ... but also	not only ... and also
neither ... nor	neither ... or
either ... or	either ... nor
both ... and	both ... as well as
whether ... or	whether ... nor
as ... as	as ... than
so ... that	so ... which

Worked Example 1

Correct: Although he was tired, but he continued working.

Two contrast signals in one sentence. Drop one.

Answer: Although he was tired, he continued working. (*but* removed)

Worked Example 2

Correct: He is not only hardworking, and also creative.

Correlative pair: **not only ... but also**. *And also* breaks the pair.

Answer: He is not only hardworking, **but also** creative.

Worked Example 3

Correct: Despite he was ill, he came to school.

Despite is a preposition. It takes a noun or gerund — not a clause with a subject and verb.

Answer: **Despite being** ill, he came to school.

Practice Questions — Connector Errors

Identify and correct the connector error in each sentence.

1. She studied hard, so she failed the exam.
2. Although the policy was popular, but it was poorly executed.
3. He is not only intelligent, and also diligent.
4. Neither John or Mary was invited to the event.
5. Despite he was late, he managed to complete the task.
6. She works hard, so she never achieves her targets.
7. Both the teacher as well as the students were present.
8. Whether he passes or not remains uncertain.
9. Although she was nervous, but she delivered an excellent speech.
10. She studied hard, however she failed the test.
11. Because he was tired, so he went to bed early.

Section G — Word Form Errors — Adjective / Adverb [STAMP CARD: A]

An adjective modifies a noun. An adverb modifies a verb, adjective, or another adverb. This is the most frequently tested error type. The error is almost always an adjective used where an adverb is needed.

Question Type 1: Identify the wrong word form

Technique: Find the describing word. Identify what it modifies. Then choose the correct word class.

Step 1: Find the word you are checking.

Step 2: Find what it is modifying or what role it plays in the sentence.

Step 3: Apply the rule:

- Modifies a noun → adjective
- Modifies a verb, adjective, or adverb → adverb (typically -ly)
- Is the subject or object → noun
- Expresses the action → verb

Step 4: Convert to the correct form.

Worked Example 1

Correct: He spoke **confident** in front of the class.

Step 1: Word to check: *confident*.

Step 2: It modifies *spoke* — a verb. → Adverb form required.

Step 3: *confident* (adjective) → *confidently* (adverb).

Answer: He spoke **confidently** in front of the class.

Worked Example 2

Correct: ...unable to cope mentally and physical ...

Step 1: Word to check: *physical*.

Step 2: It modifies *cope* — a verb. → Adverb form required.

Step 3: Also check parallel structure: *mentally* (adverb) and *physical* (adjective) — the two must match.

Answer: ...unable to cope mentally and **physically** ...

Worked Example 3

Correct: Her improve was remarkable.

Step 1: Word to check: *improve* (verb form). It is used as the subject.

Step 2: The subject of a sentence must be a noun.

Step 3: Convert to noun form: *improve* → *improvement*.

Answer: Her **improvement** was remarkable.

Word-Form Conversion Reference

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
beauty	beautify	beautiful	beautifully
care	care	careful / careless	carefully / carelessly
efficiency	—	efficient	efficiently
confidence	—	confident	confidently
significance	signify	significant	significantly
success	succeed	successful	successfully
necessity	necessitate	necessary	necessarily
fluency	—	fluent	fluently
frequency	—	frequent	frequently
health	—	healthy	healthily

Flat adverbs (no -ly):

- *hard* → work hard (NOT *hardly* = almost not at all — a different word)
- *fast* → run fast (NOT *fastly* — not a word)
- *late* → arrive late (NOT *lately* = recently — a different meaning)
- *high* → fly high (NOT *highly* = to a great degree — a different meaning)

Key Principle — Confusable Adjective Pairs

Some adjective pairs look similar but have entirely different meanings. The exam often tests these.

- **economic** = relating to the economy | **economical** = thrifty, cost-saving
The economic outlook is poor. | *This car is economical.*
- **historic** = important in history | **historical** = relating to the past
A historic speech. | *A historical novel.*
- **classic** = of high quality, traditional | **classical** = relating to ancient Greece/Rome, or to

traditional art forms
A classic film. | Classical music.

- **sensitive** = easily affected | **sensible** = showing good judgement
Sensitive skin. | A sensible decision.

Key Principle — Verb vs Noun Confusables

Some words have a verb form and a noun form that sound similar but are spelled differently. The exam may test the wrong word class.

- **advise** (verb) | **advice** (noun)
I advise you to study. | She gave me good advice.
- **affect** (verb, to influence) | **effect** (noun, a result)
The weather affects mood. | The effect was clear.
- **practise** (verb, British) | **practice** (noun, British)
I practise piano daily. | Daily practice is essential.

Singapore convention: Singapore follows British spelling. Use *practise* (verb) and *practice* (noun).

Practice Questions — Word Form Errors

Identify and correct the word form error in each sentence.

1. She handled the situation very efficient.
2. The beauty girl won the national competition.
3. Her improve over the semester was remarkable.
4. He drives careful on the expressway every day.
5. The students were extreme disappointed with their results.
6. She sings beautiful on stage every performance.
7. He is a fluency English speaker who lives abroad.
8. They work hardly to meet every single deadline.
9. The team performed impressive under difficult conditions.
10. She is a success businesswoman who founded three companies.
11. The economical situation in the country is worsening.
12. The teacher gave me good advise on my essay.

Section H — Singular / Plural and Determiner Errors [STAMP CARD: R]

R covers two related error types: (1) a noun in the wrong number; (2) a determiner or quantifier that does not match its noun. Do not confuse R with S. S is about the verb not agreeing with the subject. R is about the noun itself being in the wrong form, or its determiner being wrong.

Key Principle — Countable vs Uncountable

A **countable** noun can be counted: one book, two books. An **uncountable** noun cannot be directly counted: information, advice, water.

The quantifiers and determiners that can be used with a noun depend entirely on this distinction:

- **Countable plural:** many, few, several, a number of, these, those, both
- **Uncountable:** much, little, a great deal of, a piece of

“Many informations” is wrong because *information* is uncountable — it has no plural form. Correct: **much information**.

Question Type 1: Match determiner to noun

Technique: Identify whether the noun is countable or uncountable. Then match the determiner from the appropriate column.

Step 1: Identify the noun.

Step 2: Decide: countable plural, countable singular, or uncountable?

Step 3: Match the determiner against the rule table below.

Step 4: Replace the determiner if it does not match. If the noun itself is in the wrong form (e.g. *informations*), correct that instead.

Part 1 — Determiners and their rules

Determiner	Use With	Reason
many	Countable plural only	Counts individual items.
much	Uncountable only	Measures a mass quantity.
few / a few	Countable plural	A small countable amount.
little / a little	Uncountable	A small uncountable amount.
fewer	Countable plural	Comparative of <i>few</i> .
less	Uncountable	Comparative of <i>little</i> .
number of (a/the)	Countable	<i>a number of</i> = plural verb; <i>the number of</i> = singular verb.
amount of	Uncountable	Cannot be used with countable plurals.
this / that	Singular nouns only	Demonstratives for one item.
these / those	Plural nouns only	Demonstratives for multiple items.
every / each	Singular countable only	Treats each item individually.

Part 2 — Common error vs correct usage

Determiner	Common Error	Correct
many	many information	much information
much	much students	many students
few / a few	few time	little time
little / a little	little students	few students
fewer	less books	fewer books
less	less students	fewer students
number of	A number of students was late.	A number of students were late.
amount of	amount of students	number of students
this / that	this patients	these patients
these / those	these information	this information
every / each	every students	every student

Key Principle — Amount vs Number

The *amount/number* distinction works exactly like *less/fewer*:

- **amount** → uncountable: *a large amount of water, a small amount of advice*
- **number** → countable plural: *a large number of students, a small number of complaints*

Common error: “A large amount of students attended.” → Wrong. *Students* is countable. Correct: “A large **number** of students attended.”

Memory aid: If you can count it, use *number*. If you can only measure it, use *amount*.

Uncountable Nouns — No Plural Form

information, advice, furniture, equipment, luggage, knowledge, news, progress, research, traffic, weather, work, music, money, food (general), education, evidence, homework, accommodation, behaviour, damage, harm, luck, scenery, travel.

Irregular Plurals to Memorise

Singular	Plural
datum	data
criterion	criteria
phenomenon	phenomena
medium	media
analysis	analyses
basis	bases
hypothesis	hypotheses
curriculum	curricula

Practice Questions — Singular / Plural and Determiner Errors

Identify and correct the error in each sentence.

1. Many informations were shared at the conference yesterday.
2. Every students must submit their work by Monday morning.
3. The elderly are not just medical one.
4. She has less friends now than she did before.

5. There is many water left in the tank.
6. The criteria for selection has not been announced.
7. He ate much cookies after the examination.
8. These information is not available to the public.
9. The number of complaints are rising every single month.
10. A number of residents has complained about the excessive noise.
11. A large amount of students attended the seminar.
12. The data shows a worrying trend. (Treat 'data' as plural in formal academic usage.)

Section I — Comparative and Superlative Errors [STAMP CARD: D]

D errors involve using the wrong degree of comparison, or forming it incorrectly by combining both the -er/-est suffix and the word *more/most* on the same adjective. Three degrees: positive (base form), comparative (comparing two), superlative (comparing three or more).

Formation Rules

Adjective Type	Positive	Comparative	Superlative	Note
One syllable	tall, old	taller, older	tallest, oldest	Double final consonant if short vowel + consonant: big → bigger
One syllable -e	wide, safe	wider, safer	widest, safest	Add -r/-st only
Two syllables -y	happy, easy	happier, easier	happiest, easiest	Change -y to -i, then add -er/-est
Two+ syllables	beautiful, care-ful	more beautiful	most beautiful	Never add -er/-est
Irregular	good, bad, far	better, worse, fur-ther	best, worst, fur-theft	Memorise. Never add -er/-est or more/most

Question Type 1: Identify the wrong degree of comparison

Technique: Count the things being compared. Choose comparative for two, superlative for three or more. Check for double comparatives or superlatives.

- Step 1:** Find the adjective in comparative or superlative form.
Step 2: Count the things being compared. Two → comparative. Three or more → superlative.
Step 3: Check the formation rule: -er/-est for short adjectives; *more/most* for longer adjectives.
Step 4: If both -er/-est AND *more/most* appear on the same adjective, remove one. This is always an error.

Key Principle — How Many Things Are Being Compared?

Before choosing comparative or superlative, count the things being compared.

- **Exactly two** → comparative (-er or *more*): “She is **taller** than her sister.” (two people)
- **Three or more** → superlative (-est or *most*): “She is the **tallest** in the class.” (whole class)

The passage error *oldest* → *older*: the sentence compares the present to 2030 — two points in time.

Two = comparative. → **older**, not **oldest**.

Double comparative / superlative: If you see both *more* and *-er* on the same adjective, or both *most* and *-est* — that is always an error. Examples: *more taller*, *more better*, *most safest*, *most fastest*.

Worked Example 1

Correct: She is **more taller** than her sister.

Double comparative: *more* and *-er* cannot both be used. *Tall* is one syllable → use *-er* only.

Answer: She is **taller** than her sister.

Worked Example 2

Correct: This is the **most easiest** question.

Double superlative: *most* and *-est* cannot both be used. *Easy* ends in *-y* → use *-iest* only.

Answer: This is the **easiest** question.

Worked Example 3

Correct: He is the **most intelligent** of the two.

Of the two signals exactly two items. Two items → comparative, not superlative.

Answer: He is the **more intelligent** of the two.

Practice Questions — Degree of Comparison

Identify and correct the degree of comparison error in each sentence.

1. Singapore is one of the most safest cities in the world.
2. She is more smarter than her classmates by a significant margin.
3. Of the two candidates, she is the most qualified for the role.
4. He is the most intelligent of the two finalists.
5. This method is more better than the previous one used.
6. 25 per cent of Singaporeans will be 65 years and oldest by 2030.
7. She is more happier than she was last year.
8. This is the most simplest explanation I can provide.
9. He runs more faster than anyone else on the team.
10. Of all the students, she scored the more highly on the test.

Chapter 3. Worked Passage

Worked Passage

This chapter applies the STAMP CARD framework to a full exam-style passage, demonstrating how to identify and correct each error in order.

Section A — Annotated Exam Passage

Instructions

1. Write S-T-A-M-P-C-A-R-D in your margin before reading anything.
2. Read the entire passage once for meaning. Identify the tense. Do not correct yet.
3. Go back to line 1. For every numbered line, run through T, S, A first, then M, P, C, R, D.
4. Write your correction clearly. Tick error-free lines. Never leave any line blank.

Your Attempt

Line	Passage	Your Answer
—	Many caregivers of the elderly have their own health problems. The	—
1	average age of caregivers are about 62. It is estimated that by 2030,	
2	about 25 per cent of Singaporeans will be 65 years and oldest. The	
3	problems facing the elderly are not just medical one. Asset-rich but	
4	cash-poor, this patients are grateful for subsidies in healthcare, but	
5	what they fear most is to be afflicted through chronic diseases like	
6	dementia or stroke that leave them unable to cope mentally and	
	physical, with conditions such as depression, and often accompanied	
7	by insomnia. A person with such ailments would need not only	
8	caregivers, and also the financial means to afford long-term	
9	treatment. When the caregivers, who are often spouses and close	
10	relatives, are also unwell, the problem is compounding. Thus,	
—	Singapore needs to be prepared for the growing caregiving challenges.	—

Answer Key — Annotated

Line	Correction	STAMP	Annotated Explanation
—	Always correct.	—	Opening line; no numbered error.
1	are → is	S	Subject = the average age (singular). Strip out ‘of care-givers’. Singular subject needs singular verb.
2	oldest → older	D	Two points compared: now and 2030. Comparing two things → comparative (-er), not superlative.
3	one → ones	R	Problems (line 2) is plural. The pronoun substitute must match: ones, not one.
4	this → these	M	Patients is plural. This is for singular nouns; these is for plural nouns.
5	through → with	P	Fixed phrase: afflicted with. This preposition cannot be substituted — it must be memorised.
6	physical → physi- cally	A	Cope is a verb. Words modifying verbs must be adverbs. Parallel structure with mentally also demands -ly.
7	No error ✓	—	Tick this line. Do not force an error.
8	and → but	C	Not only ... but also is a fixed correlative pair. <i>And also</i> breaks the pair.
9	No error ✓	—	Tick this line. Do not force an error.
10	compounding → compounded	T	Past participle <i>compounded</i> describes a state. <i>Compounding</i> wrongly implies the problem is actively doing something.
—	Always correct.	—	Closing line; no numbered error.

Key Principle — Approaching Error-Free Lines

Lines 7 and 9 are error-free. Two lines are always correct in every exam passage. When you have gone through all nine STAMP CARD letters on a line and found nothing, tick it immediately and move on.

Common mistake: students who expect every line to have an error will manufacture one on the correct lines. The exam specifically includes two correct lines to test whether you can recognise grammatically sound writing. If you have checked T, S, A, M, P, C, A, R, D and found nothing — the line is correct. Tick it.

Chapter 4. Exam Tips

Exam Tips

Section A — Final Strategy

1. **Read for meaning first.** The first read of the passage is not optional — it establishes the tense and topic, essential for T and C errors. Students who skip this step miss tense errors consistently.
2. **Check T, S, A first on every line.** These three account for the majority of errors. If you are stuck, return to these three before the others.
3. **Two lines are always correct.** Do not force an error. If STAMP CARD reveals nothing on a line, tick it and move on with confidence.
4. **Write corrections clearly.** Underline the error word in the passage. Write the correction on the answer line. Ambiguous markings lose marks even when the answer is right.
5. **Each numbered line has exactly one error.** Once you have found it, move to the next line immediately. Do not look for a second error on the same line.
6. **Memorise fixed preposition phrases (P).** These are not derivable from rules. Build and maintain a personal collocation list throughout your revision.
7. **For D errors, count the things being compared.** Two → comparative. Three or more → superlative. The number is always stated or implied in the sentence.
8. **Do not guess.** If you are stuck after checking all nine letters, mark the line and return after finishing the rest. A second pass under T, S, or A almost always reveals the answer.

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